CAT 2026 Preparation Roadmap & Beginner Study Planner

Section Foundations, Phase-by-Phase Preparation Timeline, Resource Architecture & Mock Milestones

1. CAT Exam Architecture & Sectional Weightage Overview

Understand the exact structure, timing, and marking scheme of the Common Admission Test.

Section	Questions	Duration	Key Focus Areas	Target Raw Score for
VARC (Verbal Ability & RC)	24 Qs (16 RC, 8 VA)	40 Minutes	Economy, philosophy, sociology RCs, Summary, Jumbles	~38 - 42 Marks (~13-14 net correct)
DILR (Data Interpretation & LR)	20 Qs (4 Sets of 5)	40 Minutes	Arrangements, matrices, games & tournaments, charts	~30 - 34 Marks (~10-11 net correct / 2-2.5 sets)
QA (Quantitative Aptitude)	22 Qs (MCQ & TITA)	40 Minutes	Arithmetic, Algebra, Geometry, Numbers, Modern Math	~33 - 38 Marks (~11-13 net correct)
Total Exam Composite	66 Questions	120 Minutes	Holistic multi-sectional endurance under pressure	~95 - 105 Marks for 99+ Percentile

STRATEGIC PRINCIPLE: Marking System: +3 for correct, -1 for incorrect MCQ, 0 for TITA (Type in the Answer) questions.

2. The 3-Phase Beginner Preparation Timeline (9-Month Runway)

A structured progression from absolute concept clarity to timed mock endurance.

Preparation Phase	Calendar Window	Primary Learning Objective	Key Measurable Milestones
Phase 1: Foundation Rebuild	Months 1 to 3	Master 100% conceptual theory across QA & VARC	Complete NCERT/basic arithmetic; read 2 long-form essays daily
Phase 2: Sectional & Advanced Sets	Months 4 to 6	Timed sectional tests; intermediate DILR puzzles	Solve 150 DILR sets; complete 100 RC passages; 50 QA sectionals
Phase 3: Mock Testing & Optimization	Months 7 to 9	Full-length 2-hour simulation; deep error logs	Complete 25-30 national mocks; maintain 80%+ accuracy on selection

STRATEGIC PRINCIPLE: Diagnostic Rule: Take a baseline diagnostic mock on Day 1 to establish raw benchmark percentiles.

3. Weekly Study Routine for Full-Time College Students & Beginners

A balanced 18-to-22 hour weekly schedule covering all 3 sections equally.

- Monday & Wednesday (VARC): 60 mins editorial reading (Aeon / The Hindu / Guardian) + 2 RC passages with distractor analysis.
- Tuesday & Thursday (QA): 90 mins concept review + 25 topic questions (rotating Arithmetic and Algebra).
- Friday (DILR): 90 mins solving 3 complex puzzle sets untimed; write out logical constraints systematically.
- Saturday: 1 Sectional timed test (alternating weekly) + 2 hours in-depth error taxonomy logging.
- Sunday: Weekly revision of formula handbook, flashcards, and unattempted question re-solves.